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WHAT WE'D BUILD · #01

The after-hours call playbook for *HVAC* companies

How to stop losing the calls that come in after 5 PM, without buying a robot receptionist that pretends to be a person. Use it to set this up yourself, or to check what an agency is selling you.

01 Why after-hours calls matter

1 in 7

Inbound calls to residential HVAC shops that came in outside business hours in June 2025 (14.1%). In October it was 9.8%. The biggest cluster was between 5 and 9 PM.

Source: ServiceTitan, "When Summer Demand Spikes, After-Hours Calls Do Too", 3 Jun 2026. Same-store data from ServiceTitan's own customers, not a national survey. Off-hours = weekdays before 8 AM and after 5 PM, plus weekends.

Those calls are often the urgent, high-value ones: no heat, no AC, a family at home. If the caller gets voicemail, the next company on Google is one tap away.

02 Text-back first, and be honest about it

The usual fix is an AI voice that pretends to be a person and can't see your schedule. Contractors in owner forums say most callers hang up on those partway through. A text that arrives within a minute and says plainly what it is works better: the caller knows someone got the message, and nobody feels tricked.

Hi, this is the after-hours assistant for [Your Company]. Sorry we missed your call. A real tech will follow up. Two quick questions so we send the right help:

1. Is it no heat, no AC, or something else?

No heat

2. Is anyone at home who can't wait until morning (a baby, someone elderly or unwell)?

Yes, kids at home

Thanks. Our on-call tech has your details and will call you shortly.

Rules for the text: say it's an assistant in the first line, ask two questions at most, use your company name, and never promise a time you can't keep.

03 What counts as an emergency

Write your own list with your techs. A starter list:

SEND TO THE ON-CALL TECH TONIGHT	BOOK FOR THE MORNING
No heat when it's freezing outside	AC or heat running but weak
No AC in extreme heat	Strange noise, still working
Anyone vulnerable at home: babies, elderly, someone unwell	Tune-ups, quotes, new installs
Water leaking from the system onto floors or ceilings	Thermostat questions

Gas smell or a CO alarm is not a booking. The text should tell them straight away: leave the house now, don't touch light switches or anything that could spark, and once outside call 911

> and the gas company. Then alert your on-call tech.

04 The on-call handoff

When a call is an emergency, your on-call tech gets one alert with everything they need to decide in ten seconds:

- **Callback number** and name
- **Address**, with a map link
- **The problem** in the caller's own words (from the text replies)
- **A photo**, if the caller sent one (thermostat screen, error code, the unit)
- One button: **Accept**. If nobody accepts within a set time (say 10 minutes), it goes to the next tech or to you.

> A real person always makes the callback. The system only makes sure the right person knows, fast.

05 Booking into the real schedule, not a side calendar

Everything that isn't an emergency should land in the software your office already uses, with the text thread attached, so nobody retypes anything at 8 AM.

IF YOU RUN ON	WHAT "BOOKED" LOOKS LIKE
ServiceTitan	The system creates a **booking** with the customer, address, problem and texts. Your CSR turns it into a job first thing. One click, nothing retyped.
Jobber	The system creates a **request** for the client and property, which your office converts into a job or quote.
Housecall Pro or others	Same idea: it lands where your team already looks each morning.

Keeping a person in that last step is on purpose. The system does the typing; your office still says yes.

06 5 questions to ask any agency before you buy

1. **Does it say it's an assistant, or does it pretend to be a person?**
   If it pretends, callers who figure it out hang up and don't call back.
2. **Can it see and write to my real schedule?**
   Ask them to show it booking into ServiceTitan or Jobber live, not a demo calendar.
3. **What happens when it's unsure?**
   The right answer: it hands off to a person. The wrong answer: it guesses.
4. **Who fixes it at 9 PM on a Saturday when it breaks?**
   Get a name and a response time in writing.
5. **What's the smallest first step?**
   A good partner starts with one thing (the text-back) and proves it before selling you the rest.

Want this mapped to your setup?

Orbiqon builds automation inside the software your business already runs on, with a person approving anything that costs money or trust. We'll look at how your after-hours calls work today and show you what we'd build. 20 minutes, no pitch deck.

Book a call at orbiqon.com

Example messages and lists are illustrations to adapt, not legal or safety advice. Gas guidance follows US state utility regulators (for example the Pennsylvania PUC): leave first, then call 911 and your gas company from outside.